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DIGITAL_LITERACY_CSE001

CASE STUDY REPORT FILE

INTRODUCTION

In today's world, almost every student has a smartphone, a laptop, and at least a handful of apps they use every day. Creating presentations, collaborating on documents, building profiles on LinkedIn or GitHub — these have become routine parts of student life. From the outside, this looks like digital confidence. But confidence in using a tool is very different from actually understanding what that tool does, who it affects, and what risks it carries.

This report is based on a case study that follows Arjun, a second-year engineering student who is digitally active in almost every sense of the word — yet repeatedly finds himself making decisions that reflect a gap between awareness and action. His experiences with online identity, group collaboration, professional communication, and cyber fraud are not extraordinary. In fact, they are remarkably common. That is precisely what makes them worth examining.

As a first-year Computer Science student specialising in Cyber Security and Digital Forensics, this case study sits close to the subjects I am studying and, honestly, close to the habits I have developed too. The line between knowing what is right and actually doing what is right in digital spaces is thinner than most of us would like to admit.

The sections that follow analyse Arjun's situation across six dimensions — from how students build digital identities to how cyber criminals exploit the very behaviours that modern platforms encourage. The goal is not to simply describe what went wrong, but to understand why it keeps going wrong, and what genuine digital literacy actually looks like beyond the surface.

Section A: Establishing the Context

We live in a time where digital tools are everywhere. Students use Canva to design presentations, Google Docs to write assignments together, GitHub to store code, and LinkedIn to present themselves to the world. On the surface, this level of activity suggests that today's students are digitally capable. But there is a difference between being digitally active and being digitally aware, and that difference is exactly what this case study is built around.

The gap is simple to describe but easy to miss in everyday life. A student who knows how to use Canva may not understand copyright. A student who uploads code to GitHub may not realise that incomplete or copied work is publicly visible to future employers. A student who collaborates on Google Docs may not notice that the platform records every edit, every contribution, and every absence of contribution. The tools work. The understanding, however, often does not keep up.

This gap exists for a very specific reason. Most digital platforms today are designed to be easy. Drag and drop. Ready-made templates. One-click sharing. AI-generated suggestions. The easier a tool becomes, the less a person needs to think about what they are actually doing. And when thinking is reduced, awareness tends to follow. Students become comfortable operating within systems without ever questioning how those systems work, what data they collect, or what consequences their actions might carry.

What makes this especially significant is that the tools themselves create an illusion. Because the output looks polished — a well-designed slide, a complete-looking GitHub profile, a shared document with multiple contributors — it is easy to assume that genuine understanding exists behind it. But appearance and understanding are not the same thing. Arjun's case makes this clear. His profiles looked active and capable. His group assignment looked complete and well-structured. His communication felt efficient to him. In each case, the surface told a different story from the reality underneath.

This is the core distinction the case study draws attention to: the difference between digital participation and digital literacy. Participation means using platforms, showing up, contributing to the visible output. Literacy means understanding the impact of what you are doing, taking responsibility for it, and recognising the risks that come with it. Most students today are strong participants. Far fewer are genuinely literate in this deeper sense.

From a Cyber Security and Digital Forensics perspective, this gap is not just an academic concern — it is a practical one. The same student who does not question a template on Canva is also the student who does not question a suspicious email. The same habit of trusting appearances over details that leads to a poorly curated LinkedIn profile is the same habit that makes phishing attacks successful. Digital behaviour is consistent. If a person does not develop the habit of questioning in low-risk situations, they are unlikely to develop it suddenly when the stakes are high.

The case study also highlights something important about how widespread availability of platforms has changed student expectations. Because tools are free, accessible, and easy to learn, there is a growing assumption that being present on these platforms is enough. Having a LinkedIn account is treated as equivalent to having professional skills. Having a GitHub repository is treated as equivalent to having coding ability. Having a shared document is treated as equivalent to having collaborated meaningfully. The platforms reward presence and output, not depth or understanding. Over time, students begin to optimise for visibility rather than competence, because that is what the systems around them seem to reward.

This situation matters because the consequences are not always immediate. Arjun's mistakes did not ruin his academic record overnight. His poorly written email did not cost him the opportunity entirely. His incomplete GitHub profile did not prevent him from submitting assignments. But these things accumulate. Digital records are permanent. Habits formed now carry forward. And in a field like Cyber Security, where the ability to question, verify, and think critically is not optional but essential, the cost of remaining unaware is far greater than it might appear in a first-year classroom.

The real problem, as this case study reveals, is not that students lack access to knowledge. Most of the information about copyright, professional communication, online safety, and digital ethics is available and has been taught at some point. The problem is that knowledge without reflection does not change behaviour. And behaviour, far more than knowledge, is what determines outcomes in digital environments.

Section B: Digital Identity and Ethics

Position: Digital presence benefits students, but only when built with honesty and awareness — without these, it exposes them to risks that quietly grow over time.

Building a digital presence has become almost expected of students today. Professors encourage it. Career advisors recommend it. Job portals filter candidates based on it. LinkedIn, GitHub, Kaggle, Stack Overflow — these platforms have become the new resume, the new first impression, the new proof of ability. And on the surface, this seems like a positive development. Students now have the ability to showcase their work, connect with professionals, and create opportunities that did not exist a generation ago. But the moment we look closer, a more complicated picture begins to emerge.

The Equal Opportunity Argument — and Where It Falls Short

One of the strongest arguments in favour of digital platforms is that they create equal opportunity. A student from a small town with no industry connections can, in theory, build a GitHub profile that gets noticed by a company in another city or even another country. A student without access to expensive coaching can publish projects, write articles, and demonstrate skills entirely on their own terms. The internet removes certain traditional barriers — background, location, financial access to networks — and replaces them with something more democratic: visible work.

This argument is appealing, and it is not entirely wrong. There are genuine examples of students who have built careers through consistent, honest digital presence. However, the ideal does not always match reality. Equal access to platforms does not mean equal ability to use them effectively. A student who has been taught how to write clean code, structure a professional profile, and communicate online clearly will always have an advantage over a student who simply creates an account and fills it in quickly. The platform is equal. The preparation behind it is not.

In Arjun's case, he had access to all the right platforms. LinkedIn, GitHub, Kaggle — the tools were there. But without the awareness to use them honestly and strategically, his presence created more of a liability than an asset. His repositories contained incomplete code. His listed skills were exaggerated. Instead of standing out positively, his profile risked creating confusion or distrust for anyone who looked carefully. Equal access to opportunity means very little if the student does not understand what they are actually doing on these platforms.

Performance Over Authenticity

This leads directly to the second issue: the pressure to perform rather than to be genuine. Digital platforms are built around visibility. Likes, connections, followers, endorsements — everything is measured and displayed. This creates an environment where the appearance of competence becomes more valuable than competence itself, at least in the short term.

Students learn quickly that a well-formatted profile with confident language gets more attention than an honest but incomplete one. They see peers listing skills they barely know, receiving internship calls, and building networks. The rational response, in a competitive environment, is to do the same. Not out of deliberate dishonesty, but out of a genuine belief that this is simply how the system works.

Arjun did exactly this. He was not trying to deceive anyone in a calculated way. He was trying to keep up. He believed that presenting himself in the best possible light was expected, even required. And that belief is understandable — because in many ways, the platforms themselves encourage it. LinkedIn prompts you to add more skills. GitHub displays contribution graphs that reward daily activity over quality. Kaggle ranks users on leaderboards. Every design choice nudges students toward performance rather than reflection.

The problem is that this behaviour, when normalised, gradually replaces learning with presentation. Students stop asking whether they actually understand something and start asking whether it looks like they understand something. Over time, the gap between the profile and the person widens. And when that gap is eventually exposed — in an interview, in a follow-up question, in a professional setting — the consequences are far more damaging than if honesty had been maintained from the start.

Misrepresentation — Dishonesty or Survival?

The question of misrepresentation is one of the more uncomfortable parts of this discussion, because the answer is not clean. Is exaggerating skills on LinkedIn ethically wrong? Technically, yes. Is it widely practised? Also yes. Does the competitive pressure students face make it understandable? To a degree.

The distinction worth drawing here is between strategic framing and outright misrepresentation. Presenting a beginner-level project confidently, describing it well, and being honest about the stage you are at — that is acceptable. Listing a skill as proficient when you have only watched one tutorial on it — that is misrepresentation, even if it feels minor.

From a Cyber Security perspective, this matters beyond just ethics. Digital platforms are increasingly used for identity verification, professional background checks, and trust-based systems. A student who develops the habit of misrepresenting themselves online is also developing a habit of treating digital identity as something that can be shaped and manipulated without consequence. That mindset, carried into professional or technical roles, becomes genuinely dangerous. In fields where accuracy and integrity are non-negotiable — forensics, security, compliance — the habit of bending truth for convenience has no place.

The norm in competitive environments may lean toward exaggeration, but normalising it does not make it acceptable. It makes it a problem that is harder to identify and address because everyone around you is doing it too.

Digital Permanence and Accountability

Perhaps the most serious dimension of digital identity is one that students rarely consider when they are young and building their first profiles: the internet does not forget.

Arjun's early GitHub commits — the incomplete code, the copied solutions, the half-finished repositories — remain visible. His early answers on Stack Overflow or Quora, written without deep understanding, are still searchable. Unlike a bad grade that sits in an academic record few people access, digital footprints are public, searchable, and permanent by default.

The question of whether students should be held accountable for things posted without full awareness is a genuinely difficult one. There is a reasonable argument that early mistakes, made without understanding, should not define a person permanently. Growth should be recognised. Context should matter.

However, this argument has limits. Ignorance of how digital permanence works does not change the fact that the record exists. And the solution is not to lower the standard of accountability — it is to raise the level of awareness before students begin creating these records in the first place. The responsibility lies partly with institutions to teach this early, and partly with students to take it seriously once taught.

What makes Arjun's situation particularly relevant here is that he was not completely unaware. He had been taught, at some level, about online identity and professional presence. The problem was that he did not connect that knowledge to his own behaviour. He knew the theory but did not apply it to himself. That disconnect — between knowing and applying — is the central ethical failure this case study describes.

Taking a Clear Position

To return to the original question: does building a digital presence genuinely benefit students, or does it expose them to more risks than they realise?

The honest answer is both — but which one dominates depends entirely on the awareness and integrity the student brings to it. A digital presence built honestly, updated carefully, and maintained with an understanding of its permanence is a genuine asset. It opens doors, creates credibility, and reflects real growth over time.

A digital presence built quickly, inflated for appearance, and treated as a performance rather than a record becomes a liability. It creates gaps that surface at the worst moments. It builds habits of misrepresentation that carry into professional life. And in a field like Cyber Security and Digital Forensics, where trust, accuracy, and integrity are the foundation of every role, those habits are not just ethically problematic — they are professionally disqualifying.

The platforms are not the problem. The lack of awareness around how to use them responsibly is. And that is something that can be changed — but only if students are willing to be honest with themselves first.

Section C: Collaboration vs. Misuse

Opening Position: Digital collaboration platforms genuinely improve the process of working together — but without accountability built into how they are used, they quietly enable avoidance more than they enable learning.

Group work has always come with its challenges. Unequal effort, last-minute contributions, members who show up for the final submission but not for the actual work — none of this is new. What digital platforms have changed is not the problem itself, but the scale at which it can happen and the ease with which it can go unnoticed. When a group works in a physical space, unequal participation is visible. When a group works across Google Docs and shared slides at different times of the day, it becomes far easier to contribute minimally while appearing to be fully involved.

This is the tension at the heart of Section C, and Arjun's group assignment illustrates it almost perfectly.

Are Collaboration Platforms Actually Enhancing Learning?

To answer this fairly, it is worth starting with what these platformsgenuinely do well. Google Docs, shared coding environments, Miro, and similar tools have madeit possible for students to work together across distances, time zones, and schedules. Versionhistory means no work is accidentally lost. Comment threads allow feedback without interrupting someone's workflow. Real-time editing means a group can build something together evenifthey are never in the same room at the same time.

For students who engage genuinely, these tools are powerful. They reflect how professional environments actually operate. Remote collaboration, shared documentation, and asynchronous communication are standard in most modern workplaces, and particularly in technology fields. A student who learns to use these tools effectively during their degree is genuinely better prepared for what comes after it.

From a Cyber Security and Digital Forensics standpoint, collaborative platforms also introduce students to concepts that are directly relevant to their field — access logs, version control, edit histories, and user activity tracking. These are not just features of Google Docs. They are the same principles that underpin audit trails, digital evidence, and system monitoring in professional security environments. Learning to work within these systems builds familiarity with how digital activity is recorded, which is foundational knowledge for anyone entering this field.

So yes — digital collaboration platforms, used properly, do enhance learning. That is the strongest argument in their favour, and it is a fair one.

Where the Same Tools Enable Shortcuts

However, the same features that make these platforms powerful also make them easy to misuse. And the misuse does not always look like misuse from the outside. That is what makes it particularly difficult to address.

In Arjun's group, the final document looked polished. Multiple names appeared on the first slide. The submission was complete and scored well. But the actual distribution of effort told a completely different story. One student had carried most of the work. Others made minor edits or added content copied from online sources with little modification. Arjun himself relied heavily on what was already written rather than contributing original thinking.

The platform did not distinguish between these levels of effort. It recorded activity, not quality. It showed that multiple users had opened and edited the document, but it could not measure whether those edits reflected genuine understanding or surface-level participation. The system treated everyone equally because the output appeared equal — even when the learning behind it was not.

This is where digital collaboration creates a specific kind of problem. It does not just allow free-riding — it makes free-riding harder to detect, easier to justify, and simpler to hide behind a shared submission. The student who did the least work received the same grade as the student who did the most. And because the platform itself showed their name in the edit history, there was a paper trail of participation that did not reflect the reality of their contribution.

Where Is the Line Between Collaboration and Academic Dishonesty?

This is perhaps the most genuinely ambiguous question in this section, because the boundary is not always obvious — even to students who are trying to act honestly.

Collaboration means working together, sharing ideas, building on each other's thinking, and dividing tasks in a way where everyone contributes meaningfully. Academic dishonesty means submitting work as your own when it was not, or benefiting from a group submission without contributing to the understanding behind it.

The line between the two becomes blurred in digital environments for a specific reason: contribution can be faked. Editing a sentence someone else wrote, adding a slide with content copied from a website, leaving a comment on a section you did not read — these actions register as participation without constituting genuine collaboration. The platform cannot tell the difference. The faculty often cannot either, unless they probe individually, as happened in Arjun's case during the follow-up discussion.

What revealed the truth was not the platform — it was the conversation. When individual members were asked to explain parts of the presentation they were supposedly responsible for, the understanding simply was not there for several of them. The assignment had been completed. The learning had not happened.

This is the clearest possible illustration of where the boundary lies. Collaboration produces shared understanding. Misuse produces shared submission. The output may look the same. The difference shows up the moment anyone asks a follow-up question.

Does Digital Invisibility Make Ethical Behaviour Harder to Enforce?

Honestly, yes — but that is not the whole answer.

When individual effort is not immediately visible, the temptation to contribute less is stronger. This is not unique to students. It is a well-documented behaviour in any group setting where accountability is unclear. Digital environments amplify this because the physical cues that make laziness visible — someone sitting quietly while others work, someone arriving late, someone clearly not keeping up — simply do not exist in the same way when the work happens asynchronously online.

This does make enforcement harder. Faculty cannot watch a shared document the way they can observe a group working in a classroom. Contribution histories can be manipulated — opening a document and making a minor edit leaves a timestamp even if the actual effort was minimal. The tools that are meant to support transparency can also be used to simulate it.

However, enforcement is only one part of the equation. The more important question is whether students develop the internal accountability to engage honestly even when no one is watching. That is a harder thing to teach, but it is ultimately more valuable. A student who contributes genuinely to a group assignment because they want to actually learn — not because they fear being caught — is developing a habit of integrity that will serve them far beyond the assignment itself.

In a field like Cyber Security, this matters practically. Digital forensics professionals work with evidence. Security analysts work with systems where small oversights have large consequences. The habit of cutting corners in low-stakes group assignments is the same habit that, in a professional setting, could mean missing a critical detail in an investigation or ignoring a process because it feels unnecessary. Integrity in small things is practice for integrity in larger ones.

The Steelman Argument — And My Response To It

The strongest possible argument in favour of digital collaboration, stated as fairly as I can manage it, is this:

Digital collaboration platforms reflect the reality of modern professional work. They teach students to communicate asynchronously, divide responsibilities, manage shared documents, and produce outcomes as a team. Restricting or penalising their use because some students misuse them would be like banning calculators because some students use them without understanding the maths. The tool is not the problem. Restricting good tools to manage bad

behaviour punishes everyone and prepares students less effectively for the workplace they are entering.

This is a genuinely strong argument. And I agree with parts of it. I agree that these platforms should not be restricted. I agree that learning to collaborate digitally is a legitimate and important skill. I agree that the existence of misuse is not a reason to remove tools that work well for students who engage honestly.

Where I disagree is with the implication that the current approach is sufficient. Allowing these tools without building structured accountability around them — individual reflections, follow-up discussions, contribution assessments, or any mechanism that tests whether individual understanding exists behind the group output — is not good enough. The tool itself cannot be the only measure of participation. The learning behind the output also has to be verified.

Digital collaboration improves learning significantly when it is paired with individual accountability. Without that pairing, it improves outputs — which is a very different thing.

Section D: Cyber Awareness and Responsibility

Opening Position: Cyber crimes continue to succeed not because people are ignorant, but because awareness alone is never enough to override instinct, urgency, and trust in the moment.

If someone asked Arjun before the phishing incident whether he knew what phishing was, he would have said yes. He had been taught about it. He understood the concept. He could probably have described how it works and what signs to look for. And yet, when a convincing email landed in his inbox at exactly the right moment — when he was actively searching for internships and feeling the pressure of deadlines — all of that knowledge stepped aside. The opportunity felt real, the email looked legitimate, and he clicked the link.

This is the central problem this section addresses. Cyber crimes do not primarily succeed because users have never heard of them. They succeed because knowing about a threat and responding correctly to it in a real moment are two completely different things.

Why Cyber Crimes Keep Working Despite Awareness

Security awareness campaigns have been running for years. Schools teach it. Institutions send guidelines. Government portals like CERT-In publish regular advisories. The information is available, accessible, and repeatedly communicated. And yet phishing, identity theft, and online fraud continue to affect thousands of people every year, including educated, tech-aware individuals.

The reason is behavioural, not informational. Human decision-making in real situations is shaped by emotion, urgency, and context far more than by remembered knowledge. Attackers understand this better than most security trainers do. A phishing email is not designed to trick someone who is calm, careful, and thinking clearly. It is designed to reach someone who is busy, hopeful, slightly distracted, or under pressure — and in that state, trigger a response before the thinking brain catches up with the instinctive one.

Arjun's case demonstrates this precisely. The email created urgency — limited slots, twelve-hour deadline, immediate action required. It targeted a specific desire — an internship he had been actively working toward. It looked professional enough to pass a quick glance. These three elements combined were enough to override the awareness he already had. He did not forget what phishing was. He simply did not apply that knowledge in the moment because the situation did not feel like a threat. It felt like an opportunity. This is why cyber crimes keep succeeding. They do not look like attacks. They look like exactly what the victim most wants to see.

Individual Responsibility vs. Platform and Institutional Accountability

There is a genuine debate here about where responsibility lies, and it is worth engaging honestly rather than defaulting to the easy answer that users should simply be more careful.

On one side, individual responsibility is real and cannot be dismissed. Arjun had been taught the warning signs. He had the knowledge to verify the email before responding. He chose not to, or more accurately, he acted before that choice even registered consciously. That is on him, to a degree. Personal digital safety requires active habits, and those habits have to be maintained consistently — not just remembered in theory.

On the other side, placing all responsibility on the individual ignores the environment those individuals operate in. Digital platforms are deliberately designed to encourage fast responses. Notification systems, urgency cues, limited-time prompts — these are not accidents. They are design choices that prioritise engagement over reflection. When the platforms that people use every day are engineered to reduce the time between seeing something and acting on it, blaming users entirely for acting too quickly is not entirely fair.

Institutions carry responsibility too. Teaching cyber security as a one-off module or including it in an orientation session is not sufficient. If the goal is behaviour change rather than knowledge transfer, then the approach needs to be different — repeated, practical, scenario-based, and tied to real situations students actually encounter. Reading about phishing in a textbook does not prepare someone for a convincing phishing email the way a realistic simulation does.

From a Cyber Security and Digital Forensics perspective, this balance of responsibility is something the field deals with constantly. Organisations design systems with the assumption that users will make mistakes — because they will. Security architecture does not rely solely on user awareness. It builds in layers of protection precisely because human behaviour is unpredictable under pressure. That same thinking needs to be applied to how digital safety is taught and enforced at the student level.

Negligence, Lack of Education, or Systemic Failure?

Consider the scenario directly: a student falls victim to an online scam due to lack of awareness. How should this be viewed?

Calling it pure negligence is too simple. Negligence implies a clear standard was known and ignored. But if the student was never taught to recognise the specific tactics used — urgency framing, domain spoofing, credential harvesting disguised as verification — then falling for it is not negligence. It is a gap in preparation.

Calling it purely a lack of education is also incomplete. Arjun had received education on this topic. The problem was not that the information had never reached him. The problem was that the education did not change his behaviour when it mattered.

The most accurate framing is systemic failure — a combination of insufficient practical training, platform design that rewards speed over caution, and an educational approach that measures knowledge rather than behaviour. The student is not blameless, but they are also not the only point of failure. The system around them contributed to the outcome.

Are Current PreventiveMeasuresEnough?

The standard toolkitforcybersafety—strongpasswords,two-factor authentication, awareness posters, annual trainingmodules—addressesthesurfaceofthe problem without reaching its root. These measuresassumethatifapersonknowstherightthing to do, they will do it. But as this case study hasshownrepeatedly,thatassumptiondoesnot hold under real conditions.

What is missing isbehaviouraltraining.Simulatedphishingexercises, where students receive fake phishing emailsandareshownimmediatelyafterwardswhat they missed and why, are far more effective thanawarenesscampaigns.Regular,low-stakes practice builds the habit of pausing and verifyingbeforeacting.Thathabit,onceformed, is far more reliable than remembered knowledge.

After the incident,Arjunbegancheckingsenderaddressescarefully, avoiding unknown links, and taking timebeforerespondingtourgentmessages.These were not new pieces of information for him.Theywereexistingknowledgethatfinallybecame consistent behaviour — because he hadexperiencedtheconsequenceofnotapplying it. The goal of cyber safety education shouldbetobuildthatbehaviourbeforetheconsequence, not after it.

Cyber safety is notalesson.Itisahabit.Andhabitsarebuiltthrough repetition and experience, not through readingalistofrulesonceayear.

Section E: Communication and Digital Etiquette

Opening Thought: The way we communicate online has changed faster than our awareness of when that change becomes a problem.

Arjun knew how to write a professional email. At some point in his academic life, he had almost certainly been taught the basics — subject line, greeting, clear body, polite closing. The knowledge existed. But when he needed to send an email to a faculty member quickly, none of that came to mind. What came naturally instead was the style he used every single day: short, direct, informal, and fast.

The email he sent — "Hi sir, I need recommendations urgently. Send asap." — was not written carelessly because he did not care about the outcome. It was written that way because that is simply how communication had come to feel normal to him. And that is the deeper issue this section is concerned with.

Why Students Fail to Maintain Professionalism Despite Knowing Better

The honest answer is habit. Most student communication today happens through WhatsApp, Instagram DMs, Discord, or similar platforms where short and informal is not just accepted — it is the norm. Messages are expected to be quick. Long, structured responses feel unusual and even slightly awkward in those spaces. Over time, this style becomes the default setting for how a person communicates, regardless of context.

The problem is not that informal communication exists. The problem is that the boundary between informal and formal spaces has become genuinely blurry for many students. When the same device is used to message friends, email professors, and apply for internships, the mental shift required to change communication style does not always happen automatically. The context changes, but the habit does not.

Arjun's email is a clear example of this. He was not being disrespectful intentionally. He was being efficient — in the way efficiency had been defined for him by years of instant messaging. The casualness was not a statement. It was simply what felt natural. And that is precisely what makes it difficult to address. Deliberate rudeness is easy to correct. Unconscious habit is much harder.

Is Informal Communication Becoming the New Normal?

There is a reasonable argument that communication norms evolve naturally over time and that what counts as professional is not fixed. Emails in many modern workplaces are shorter and less formal than they were twenty years ago. Some companies communicate entirely through Slack, where the tone is conversational by design. The strict formality of traditional professional correspondence is genuinely less common in certain industries.

This evolution is real and worth acknowledging. However, it does not erase the need for contextual awareness. The question is never really whether formal or informal communication is better in the abstract. The question is whether a person can read the situation and adjust accordingly. A student

who can communicate professionally when the moment calls for it and casually when that is appropriate demonstrates a far higher level of communication intelligence than one who defaults to the same style in every situation.

What Arjun lacked was not the ability to write formally. He demonstrated that clearly in the revised version of his email, which was structured, respectful, and appropriately detailed. What he lacked was the awareness to recognise that this particular situation required that version, not the casual one.

How Communication Style Shapes Perception and Opportunity

This matters beyond just being polite. In professional and academic contexts, communication is often the first and sometimes the only point of contact between a student and someone in a position to help them. An email to a faculty member, a message to a potential employer, a response to a recruiter — these interactions create impressions that are difficult to reverse.

A poorly written email does not just convey the message badly. It signals something about the sender — their attention to detail, their respect for the recipient's time, their seriousness about the opportunity. Even if those signals are unintentional and inaccurate, they still land. The faculty member who received Arjun's email responded formally and distantly — not because they judged him harshly, but because the tone of the exchange had already been set.

In fields like Cyber Security and Digital Forensics, written communication carries particular weight. Incident reports, forensic documentation, client-facing security assessments, and professional correspondence all require clarity, precision, and appropriate tone. The habit of communicating carefully in writing is not a soft skill that sits separately from technical ability — it is part of what makes a professional credible and trustworthy in their role.

The cost of poor digital communication is not always immediate or dramatic. But it is consistent. Every interaction that creates a slightly negative impression, every email that signals carelessness rather than capability, quietly narrows the space of opportunity available to a person. And because digital communication leaves a record, those impressions do not disappear the way a forgotten conversation does.

Section F: Personal Reflection

Before working through this case study, I had a fairly surface-level idea of what digital literacy meant. I thought it meant knowing how to use digital tools effectively — being comfortable with technology, knowing which platforms to use for which tasks, being able to navigate online spaces without getting confused. In other words, I thought it was mostly a technical thing. A skill set. Something you either had or were still developing.

Reading through Arjun's story changed that understanding in a way that felt genuinely uncomfortable at certain points — because a lot of what he did was recognisable.

The part that surprised me most was not the phishing incident, even though that was the most dramatic. It was the group assignment. The idea that a platform can record participation without recording understanding — that a document can show multiple contributors and still represent the thinking of only one or two people — is something I had not thought about carefully before. I have been in group assignments where the effort was not equal. I think most students have. But reading it laid out as clearly as this made me think about which side of that imbalance I have been on, and whether I have always been honest with myself about it.

The email section was the other moment that landed. I know how to write a professional email. That knowledge has existed for a while. But if I am honest, I do not always apply it — especially when I am in a rush or when the situation feels informal even if it technically is not. The line between a quick message to a friend and a quick message to a professor has blurred for me in the same way it did for Arjun, and I had not really examined that before.

Do I think I use digital platforms responsibly? Mostly, but not completely. My profiles are not wildly exaggerated, but I have probably listed things with more confidence than the actual depth of my knowledge justified. I have probably sent messages that were more casual than the context required. I have probably moved quickly through digital interactions without pausing to verify details the way I should, given the field I am studying.

Studying Cyber Security and Digital Forensics means I will eventually be in roles where the quality of my digital judgment directly affects outcomes for other people. That is not a responsibility that begins when I graduate. The habits I am building now are the habits I will carry into those roles. That is the part of this case study that felt most significant to me — not that Arjun made mistakes, but that his mistakes were the product of habits formed gradually, without him really noticing.

If I had to change one thing after engaging with this material, it would be the speed at which I respond to things digitally. Not slowing down dramatically, but building in a consistent pause — before sending, before clicking, before posting — to ask whether this is actually what I intend and whether I have checked what I need to check. That habit, applied consistently, would have changed almost every negative outcome in Arjun's story. And honestly, it would probably improve a few things in mine too.

■ *Conclusion*

Arjun's story does not end dramatically. He did not fail his course, lose an opportunity permanently, or face serious consequences that could not be recovered from. And that is actually what makes it such an honest and useful case study. The damage was quiet. Gradual. The kind that builds up without announcing itself — until it does.

What this case study ultimately shows is that digital literacy is not about how many platforms you use or how active your profiles look. It is about the quality of thinking that happens behind every digital action you take. Arjun used all the right tools. He had profiles on the right platforms, worked in the right collaborative spaces, and had access to the same resources as everyone around him. What he lacked was the habit of pausing to ask whether he was using those tools with genuine awareness or simply going through the motions because everyone else was.

Across every section of this report, the same pattern appeared in different forms. A digital identity built for visibility rather than honesty. A group assignment completed on the surface but not understood underneath. An email sent with efficiency in mind but without any thought for how it would land. A phishing link clicked because the desire for an opportunity outweighed the instinct to verify. Each of these moments, on its own, feels minor. Together, they describe a person who is digitally present but not digitally responsible.

As someone studying Cyber Security and Digital Forensics, this case study sits particularly close to home. The field I am entering is built entirely on the assumption that digital behaviour has consequences — that what people do online leaves traces, that those traces matter, and that understanding them requires both technical knowledge and genuine critical thinking. The habits Arjun struggled with are the same habits that, in a professional security context, could mean the difference between catching a threat and missing it entirely.

The most important takeaway from this case study is not a list of rules to follow. It is a shift in how digital activity is approached in the first place. Digital literacy, in its truest sense, means treating every online action as something that has weight — that can be seen, recorded, misread, or exploited. It means building the habit of thinking before clicking, verifying before trusting, and communicating with the same care in a formal email as you would in any other professional interaction.

Arjun eventually got there. But he got there through experience of what happens when awareness fails. The goal, for anyone engaging seriously with this material, is to get there before the lesson arrives the hard way.